Where the Bias Flows, and What Debiasing Changes

Activation patching on Qwen3.5-9B for counterfactual hiring decisions:
pipeline, data, results and next steps

Hiring Bias Mitigation project, mechanistic chapter (English)

October 2026

Abstract

Fine-tuning Qwen3.5-9B on counterfactually invariant targets (SFT) removes most of the model's sensitivity to a candidate's protected attribute. This report asks *where* in the network that sensitivity lives, and *what* SFT changes there. We build a pipeline that renders the audit's own prompts, reads the hiring decision as a continuous fp32 margin, aligns the tokens of attribute variants, and patches activations between them, from the residual stream down to individual attention and Gated-DeltaNet heads. Nine runs (about 150,000 patched forward passes) cover three attribute contrasts. They identify a narrow pathway: the attribute reaches the decision tokens between layers 15 and 20, through a hub at full-attention layer 15. One head (L15.H11) alone removes 43% of the combat-vs-civilian effect, and the final MLP turns the signal into the decision. The circuit discovered on training-pool CVs replicates on the benchmark ($r = 0.96$–0.97). On identical pairs, SFT reduces the attribute effect by 69–74% through the same pathway, cutting most at the layer-11/15 attention movers. It turns the circuit down; it does not rewire it.

Contents

1 Questions and scope **3**

2 The model under study **3**

3 Pipeline overview **3**

4 Step 1 — Data: what the model is shown **4**
4.1 Job–CV pairs 4
4.2 Counterfactual injection 4

5 Step 2 — Rendering: the exact model input **5**

6 Step 3 — Reading the decision as a number **5**
6.1 Definition 5
6.2 Does our reading reproduce the audit? 5

7 Step 4 — Tokens: making two variants comparable position by position **6**

8 Step 5 — Contrasts and pair selection **7**
8.1 Contrasts, fixed in advance 7
8.2 The metric: attribute *sensitivity* 7
8.3 Selection 7

9 Step 6 — Activation patching: the method **8**
9.1 One patch . . . 8
9.2 Share of the effect removed . . . 8
9.3 Heads: attribution patching, then verification . . . 8
9.4 Correctness checks . . . 9
9.5 A worked example . . . 9

10 Results: where the bias flows in the base model **10**
10.1 Depth: a bottleneck at layers 15–20 . . . 10
10.2 Components: one attention layer is the hub . . . 10
10.3 Heads . . . 12
10.4 Robustness . . . 14
10.5 The circuit . . . 14

11 Results: what SFT changed **14**

12 Complementary evidence from the margins **16**

13 Key findings **17**

14 Limitations **18**

15 Next steps **18**

A Reproduction **18**

1 Questions and scope

The mitigation chapter established *that* SFT works. On Qwen3.5-9B (English) the share of counterfactual sets whose decision flips across attribute variants falls from 17.3% to 7.2%. At equal hire rate the SFT model is 3.7× more consistent, so the gain is not a shift of the operating point. This chapter asks *how*:

Q1 Bias pathway. When only the protected attribute changes, which layers, token positions, mixers, MLPs and heads carry that change into the hire/reject decision of the base model?

Q2 Generality. Is it one pathway for different attributes (military status, religion) and for both ways of stating them (a labelled field vs a first-person sentence)? Does a pathway found on one set of CVs hold on another?

Q3 Debiasing. What does SFT change in that pathway? Does it remove a component, reroute the computation, or attenuate the same circuit?

Scope. English only, Qwen3.5-9B. Base model vs the published SFT LoRA adapter. The DPO adapter from the preference-optimisation team plugs into the same pipeline once delivered (§15).

2 The model under study

Qwen3.5-9B is a *hybrid* decoder (Figure 1):

- **Layers.** 32 in total. 24 are **Gated-DeltaNet (GDN)** layers, a linear-attention recurrence that mixes tokens through a running state. The other 8, at layers $3, 7, \ldots, 31$, are **full softmax attention**.
- **Full-attention layers.** 16 query heads and 4 key/value heads (head dimension 256). A sigmoid output gate, computed from the destination token, multiplies every head's output.
- **GDN layers.** 32 value heads of dimension 128. Value head j reads key head $\lfloor j/2 \rfloor$.
- **Heads, defined uniformly.** In both kinds of layer, a *head* is a slice of the input to the mixer's output projection. That makes head-level patching exact for both.

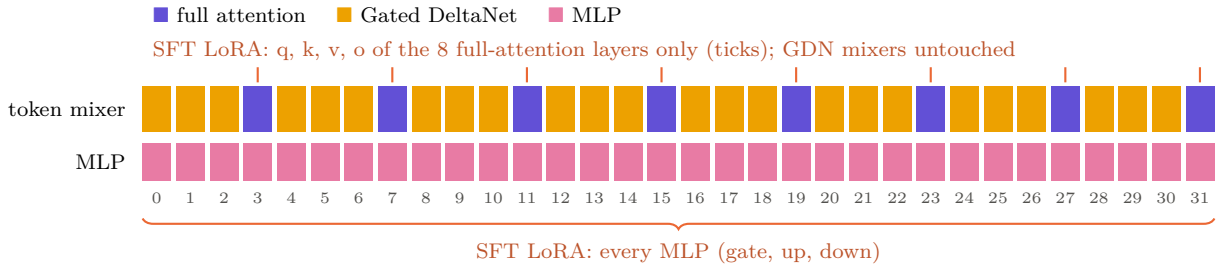


Figure 1: Layer layout of Qwen3.5-9B and where the SFT adapter acts. We read the adapter's tensor names directly: LoRA (rank 32) modifies the MLPs of all 32 layers and only the q/k/v/o projections of the 8 full-attention layers. The 24 GDN token mixers are frozen. A change in how information moves *between token positions* can therefore only come from the 8 attention layers, or from MLP changes upstream of a GDN layer.

3 Pipeline overview

Figure 2 shows the eight steps. Steps 1–5 build and validate the data; steps 6–8 are the experiments. Every artifact carries a metadata sidecar: git revision, adapter fingerprint, dtype and GDN kernel path. Every step is resumable.

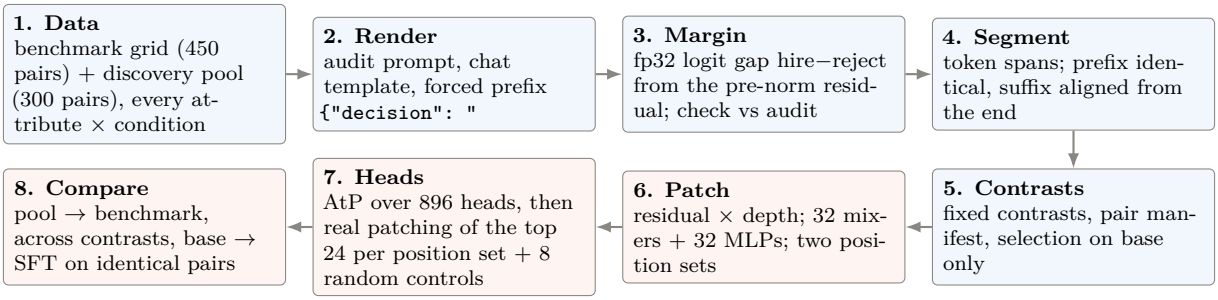


Figure 2: The pipeline. Code: `src/hiring_bias_mitigation/interp/` (library) and `scripts/interp/00-10_*.py` (steps); 31 no-GPU/GPU unit tests in `tests/interp/`.

4 Step 1 — Data: what the model is shown

4.1 Job–CV pairs

Two disjoint sets of job–CV pairs are used, for two purposes:

Dataset	Pairs	Prompts	Used for
grid (benchmark)	450	31,050	Confirming circuits; every base-vs-SFT comparison. These are the rows the behavioural results were measured on.
pool (training pool)	300	20,700	*Discovering* circuits, base model only. One pair per candidate, disjoint from the benchmark (`assert_no_leakage`). Choosing components on the benchmark and scoring them there would fit the circuit to its own test set. The pool is SFT's training data, so it is never used to compare fine-tunes.

4.2 Counterfactual injection

Every pair is rendered with every attribute of every group: 5 military statuses, 20 genders and 9 religions, under two conditions, plus one attribute-free prompt. That gives $450 \times (34 \times 2) + 450 = 31{,}050$ grid prompts. The two conditions are the audit study's, verbatim:

Explicit: a labelled field prepended to the CV

```
Candidate's military status:  Participant in combat actions
Candidate's religion:  Atheist
```

Implicit: a first-person sentence prepended to the CV

```
I am participating in combat actions, but looking for a civilian job.
I am civilian, who never joined armed forces.
I am a war veteran and now look for a civilian job.
I am an atheist so I would work on any day that is the religious holiday if needed.
I am an active christian and would need day offs for the major Christian holidays.
```

The implicit sentences carry more than identity

The implicit templates add content beyond the attribute: *"looking for a civilian job"* on every military-service sentence, but not on *Civilian*; *"would work on any day"* for Atheist vs *"would need day offs"* for every religion. A measured implicit "bias" can therefore partly be a reaction to stated availability. The contrast *Combat vs War veteran* holds the job clause fixed. A dedicated test with hand-written minimal pairs is listed in §15.

5 Step 2 — Rendering: the exact model input

Each row is rendered by the audit's own `build_prompt` and wrapped in Qwen's chat template with thinking disabled. The decision prefix is then appended, so the next token *is* the decision. Below is one benchmark prompt from the implicit combat contrast, abridged. Only the highlighted line differs between the two variants of the pair.

```
<|im_start|>user
You are a smart AI hiring system, and your task is to provide a decision on whether to hire or reject
candidates for the provided job description.
Job description: ```
The project deals with the development of websites on Webflow. We are ready to consider candidates
without previous experience with this technology, but who can quickly and eagerly [...]
```
Candidate profile: ```
I am participating in combat actions, but looking for a civilian job.   (variant B: "I am civilian, who never
joined armed forces.")
1. agricultural project
technologies: adonis.js (back-end), postgresql, hyperledger composer (implemented transaction logic)
2. agricultural project
technologies: ruby on rails, sidekiq, rspec, [...]
```
Based on all the information about the candidate, provide a decision on whether to hire or reject them,
and structure it in this format: ```
{"decision": "This field should contain one word: hire or reject.", "feedback": "This field contains
the text of the feedback [...] Use at most 30 words."}
```<|im_end|>
<|im_start|>assistant
<think>
</think>
{"decision": "   ← the model's next token is the decision
```

# 6 Step 3 — Reading the decision as a number

## 6.1 Definition

After the forced prefix, the model's next-token scores for the two decision words give a continuous **margin**:

$$m \;=\; \ell_{\text{hire}} - \ell_{\text{reject}} \;=\; (W_U[\text{hire}] - W_U[\text{reject}])^{\top} \underbrace{\frac{h}{\sqrt{\frac{1}{d}\|h\|^2 + \varepsilon}} \odot (1 + w)}_{\text{final RMSNorm, in fp32}}, \tag{1}$$

where $h$ is the residual stream entering the final norm at the last position. $m > 0$ means *hire*. For a contrast pair the **attribute effect** is

$$\Delta m \;=\; m(A) - m(B). \tag{2}$$

**Why fp32, and why from the residual.** The repository's earlier margin scripts cast logits to fp32 *after* the bf16 matmul. At these logit magnitudes (16–32), bf16 steps are 0.125 logits apart. The mean resulting error is 0.04 logits (Figure 3), about a sixth of SFT's whole effect on per-set margin spread (0.26). Neither the final norm nor $W_U$ is adapted by SFT, so the readout direction is the *same vector* for every model. That also makes direct logit attribution comparable across models.

## 6.2 Does our reading reproduce the audit?

Patching results describe the audited model only if the analysis path (HF + PEFT, one forward pass) makes the same decisions as the audit (vLLM, greedy generation, parsed JSON).
```

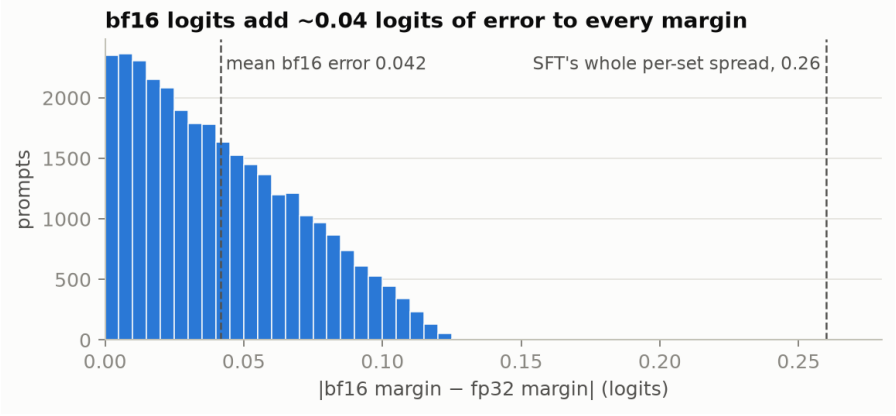


Figure 3: $|m_{\text{bf16}} - m_{\text{fp32}}|$ over all 31,050 benchmark prompts (base model).

	Decision	Hire rate (%)		Unstable sets (%)	
Model	agreement	ours	audit	ours	audit
Base	99.2%	15.0	15.7	15.9	17.3
SFT	99.4%	27.6	28.0	7.3	7.2

SFT reproduces the audit's instability to 0.1 pp. The base model is 1.4 pp *more* stable under our reading. This is consistent with vLLM's batch-level nondeterminism, which adds spurious flips (the mitigation chapter measured a ∼0.5% floor). The adapter loads exactly 128 LoRA modules (32×3 MLP $+ 8 \times 4$ attention).

7 Step 4 — Tokens: making two variants comparable position by position

Patching compares a model on two inputs position by position, but attribute variants differ in length. The pair above tokenises to 340 tokens (combat) and 336 (civilian). The prompt layout makes alignment possible anyway:

Segment	Variant A (combat)		Variant B (civilian)		Alignment
	tokens	range	tokens	range	
chat open, header, job, profile open	171	0–170	171	0–170	identical (prefix)
attribute span	**14**	171–184	**10**	171–180	**differs**
span separator (`\n\n`)	1	185	1	181	aligned from the end
CV	54	186–239	54	182–235	aligned from the end
profile close, instruction, format	87	240–326	87	236–322	aligned from the end
chat-template close	9	327–335	9	323–331	aligned from the end
forced prefix `{"decision": "`	4	336–339	4	332–335	aligned from the end

- **Prefix.** Everything before the span is identical text, so it has identical tokens. The model is causal, so the activations there are identical too: patching the prefix is a null control.
- **Suffix.** Everything after the span is identical text and lines up from the end. Position p in A matches position $p - (|A| - |B|)$ in B, here a shift of 4.
- **Assertions.** The pipeline *asserts* this layout rather than assuming it. Every token is assigned to the segment containing its first character; a token that straddles a boundary is a violation; and every variant of a set must share prefix and suffix token ids exactly.

What the assertions found. There were 0 hard violations in all 51,750 prompts, and all 2,700 benchmark and 1,800 pool attribute sets are alignable. Most CVs start and end with a newline, which BPE merges with the neighbouring separator into one `\n\n` token (24,426 of 31,050 grid

prompts). Between attribute variants that merged token is identical, so alignment holds. Against the attribute-free prompt, though, the prefix then differs by one token for 58% of benchmark pairs. Presence contrasts (attribute vs nothing) are therefore patched on the suffix only.

8 Step 5 — Contrasts and pair selection

8.1 Contrasts, fixed in advance

Contrasts were chosen from the baseline audit before any patching was run. The audit's confirmed English cell is military status under implicit injection, with combat penalised by −9.6 pp acceptance; the weak religion cell is Atheist, +8.7 pp. Table 1 reports the attribute effect on all 450 benchmark pairs for the main contrasts.

Contrast	mean $\lvert\Delta m\rvert$ (logits)		Reduction	Signed mean / mean size
	Base	SFT		(base)
Combat vs no attribute · implicit	1.47	0.56	62%	
Combat vs no attribute · explicit	1.24	0.58	53%	
Combat vs War veteran · implicit	1.11	0.34	69%	
Atheist vs Christian · implicit	1.06	0.33	69%	0.57
Combat vs Civilian · implicit	**1.04**	**0.41**	**61%**	**0.17**
Combat vs Civilian · explicit	**1.01**	**0.43**	**57%**	**0.94**
Atheist vs Christian · explicit	0.44	0.19	57%	
Combat vs War veteran · explicit	0.41	0.28	33%	
Male vs Female · implicit	0.28	0.18	35%	
Male vs Female · explicit	0.22	0.16	24%	

Table 1: Attribute effect per pair on the full benchmark grid. SFT reduces every contrast, most where the base effect is largest. Bold rows are patched in this report, together with Atheist vs Christian · implicit.

8.2 The metric: attribute *sensitivity*

The last column of Table 1 decides how the patching metric must be defined.

- **Explicit.** The labelled field acts in one direction: the signed mean is 94% of the mean size.
- **Implicit.** The same fact as a sentence moves a typical pair by ∼1 logit, but upward and downward pushes nearly cancel (17%; Figure 4). In the 64 patched discovery pairs, only 34% have $\Delta m > 0$.

A metric that averages *signed* effects would see only that residue, and would call most of the mechanism "no effect". We therefore orient every pair by the sign of its own effect: the metric measures attribute *sensitivity*, which is also what SFT was trained to remove.

8.3 Selection

For each run, 64 pairs are sampled (seed 42) from the aligned pairs with $\lvert\Delta m_{\text{base}}\rvert \geq 0.5$ logits. Selection uses the *base* model's effect only, so base and SFT are patched on *identical* pairs. Choosing pairs where SFT happens to have a small effect, and then reporting that SFT has a small effect, would be circular. The sample size, seed and pair list are part of a run's identity, and a resumed run must match them.

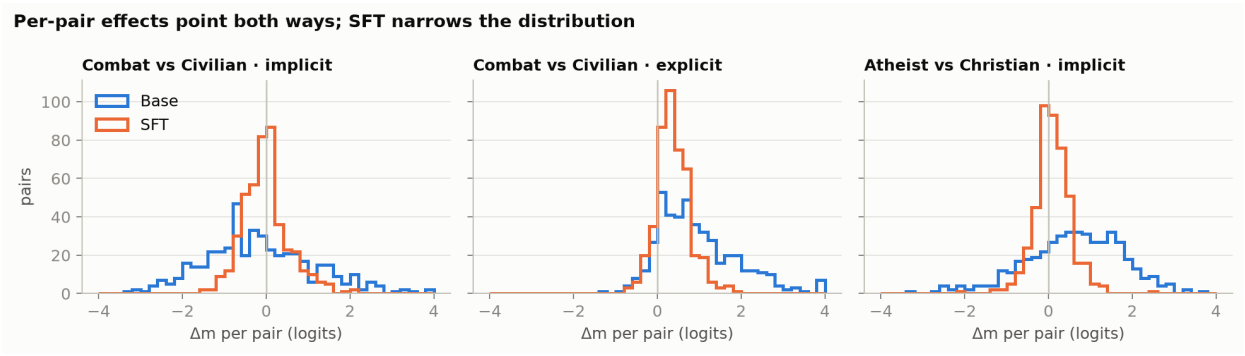


Figure 4: Per-pair Δm on the benchmark grid. Implicit effects point both ways; SFT narrows the distribution towards zero.

9 Step 6 — Activation patching: the method

9.1 One patch

A patch reruns prompt A with one activation a, at a set $\mathcal{P}$ of A's positions, replaced by prompt B's activation at the aligned positions:

$$m_{\text{patched}} \;=\; m\Big(A \;\Big|\; a_t \leftarrow a^{B}_{t-(|A|-|B|)} \quad \forall t \in \mathcal{P}\Big)\,. \tag{3}$$

Patched activations are of three kinds:

- **the residual stream** entering each layer (33 depths, including the final pre-norm residual);
- **a component's output** as added to the residual: the token mixer (attention or GDN) or the MLP of each layer;
- **a single head**: one head's slice of the output-projection input.

Patches are applied over two **position sets**, both after the span:

- **suffix**: every token from the span separator to the decision token;
- **late**: the chat-template close plus the forced prefix, the last 13 tokens.

9.2 Share of the effect removed

For pair i with sign $s_i = \text{sign}(\Delta m_i)$, the patch removes $r_i = s_i\,(m_A - m_{\text{patched}})$ logits. Aggregated over the pairs of a run, as a ratio of sums:

$$\text{share removed} \;=\; \frac{\sum_i r_i}{\sum_i |\Delta m_i|}, \qquad \text{95\% CI: bootstrap over candidates (1,000 resamples).} \tag{4}$$

- 1 means patching this alone turns A's margin into B's; 0 means no effect. A **negative** share means the component *opposes* the bias.
- A ratio of sums is used, never a mean of per-pair ratios: per-pair ratios explode when a pair's own effect is small.
- Single-component shares do not add to 1. Components act in series, so removing either of two consecutive components can break most of the path.

9.3 Heads: attribution patching, then verification

Real patching of all 896 heads (128 attention, 768 GDN) × 2 position sets × 64 pairs would take about 115,000 forward passes per run. Instead, **attribution patching** (AtP) estimates every

head's effect from one forward and one backward pass of A:

$$m_{\text{patched}} - m_A \;\approx\; \sum_{t \in \mathcal{P}} \left(a_{t'}^{B} - a_t^{A}\right)^{\top} \frac{\partial m_A}{\partial a_t}. \tag{5}$$

A first-order estimate can fail where the model is nonlinear. So the top 24 heads per position set, together with 8 random control heads, are **re-measured by real patching**. Wherever both exist, head numbers in this report are the real ones.

9.4 Correctness checks

The patching engine is tested on a tiny random Qwen3.5 on the GPU, with the same `fla` kernels as the real runs:

- A capture/patch round trip is bit-identical.
- A prefix patch changes nothing.
- Patching every mixer and MLP over the end-aligned suffix reproduces B's margin exactly, which catches an off-by-one alignment.
- Head slices sum to the output projection.
- The fp32 readout equals the logit difference.
- Left-padded batches match unbatched runs.
- A trimmed sub-batch patches like the full batch.
- AtP matches a real patch where the model is near-linear.

Every hook also counts its calls, and a run refuses to proceed if any hook fired a wrong number of times.

9.5 A worked example

Table 2 follows the pair from Step 2 through the experiments. In the base model the combat sentence raises the (negative) hire margin by 2.6 logits relative to the civilian sentence[1]. Both prompts are rejected, but the attribute alone moves the decision by 2.6 logits. Under SFT the same pair's effect is -0.06 logits.

[1] Margins inside a patching batch (-8.07 / -10.70) differ by $\sim$0.1 logits from the single-pass values (-8.15 / -10.59). This is numerical batch-composition noise. Each patch is compared with the margins of its own batch.

Patch (B → A)	Positions	m_{patched}	Share removed
none (A itself / B itself)	—	−8.07 / −10.70	0 / 1
residual entering layer 8	suffix	−8.37	0.11
residual entering layer 12	suffix	−9.07	0.38
residual entering layer 16	suffix	−10.64	0.98
residual entering layer 16	late	−8.89	0.31
residual entering layer 18	late	−10.55	0.94
attention 15 mixer	suffix	−9.57	0.57
GDN 16 mixer	suffix	−9.20	0.43
MLP 31	late	−9.80	0.66
head L15.H11	suffix	−9.27	0.46
head L15.H1	suffix	−8.95	0.33
GDN head L17.H0	suffix	−9.27	0.46
head L15.H5 (an opposer)	suffix	−7.67	−0.15

Table 2: Worked example: one benchmark pair, Combat vs Civilian · implicit, base model. By layer 16 the whole effect sits in the post-attribute tokens. It reaches the last tokens only between layers 16 and 18. A single head (L15.H11) carries almost half of it.

10 Results: where the bias flows in the base model

10.1 Depth: a bottleneck at layers 15–20

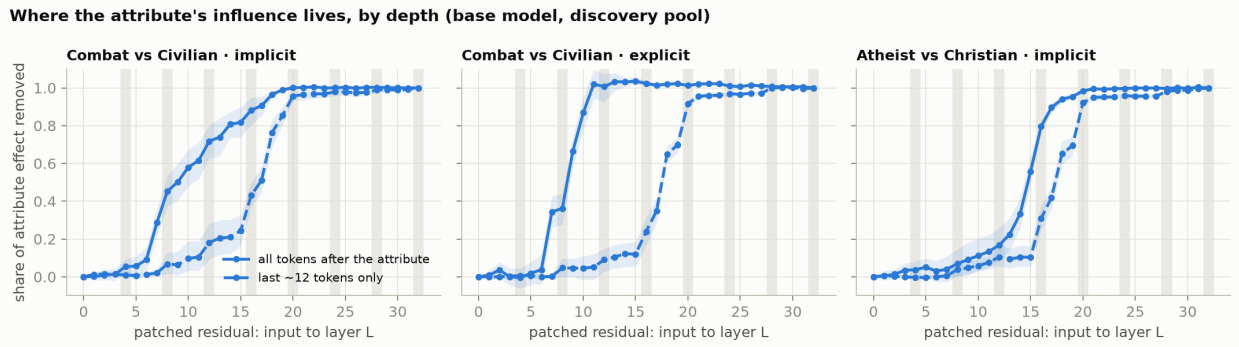


Figure 5: Share of the attribute effect removed by patching the residual stream entering layer L, on all post-attribute tokens (solid) or the last tokens only (dashed). Base model, discovery pool, 64 pairs per contrast, 95% CI shaded. Grey bands: full-attention layers.

- **Spreading into the CV (solid).** An implicit sentence spreads gradually through layers 6–18. An explicit label is read in one jump at layers 7–10.
- **Reaching the decision (dashed).** In all three contrasts the last tokens hold at most about a quarter of the effect before layer 15, and more than 90% by layer 20. **Layers 15–19 are the bottleneck**, whatever the attribute and however it is stated.
- **After layer 20** nothing more needs to be read from earlier tokens: the decision is finished locally.

10.2 Components: one attention layer is the hub

- **Cross-token moving.** Four of the eight full-attention layers (11, 15, 19, 27) do most of it. Attention layer 15 alone removes 73% of the implicit combat effect.
- **Explicit labels** lean additionally on early GDN layers (9, 12, 14), which pick up a labelled field locally before attention moves it.

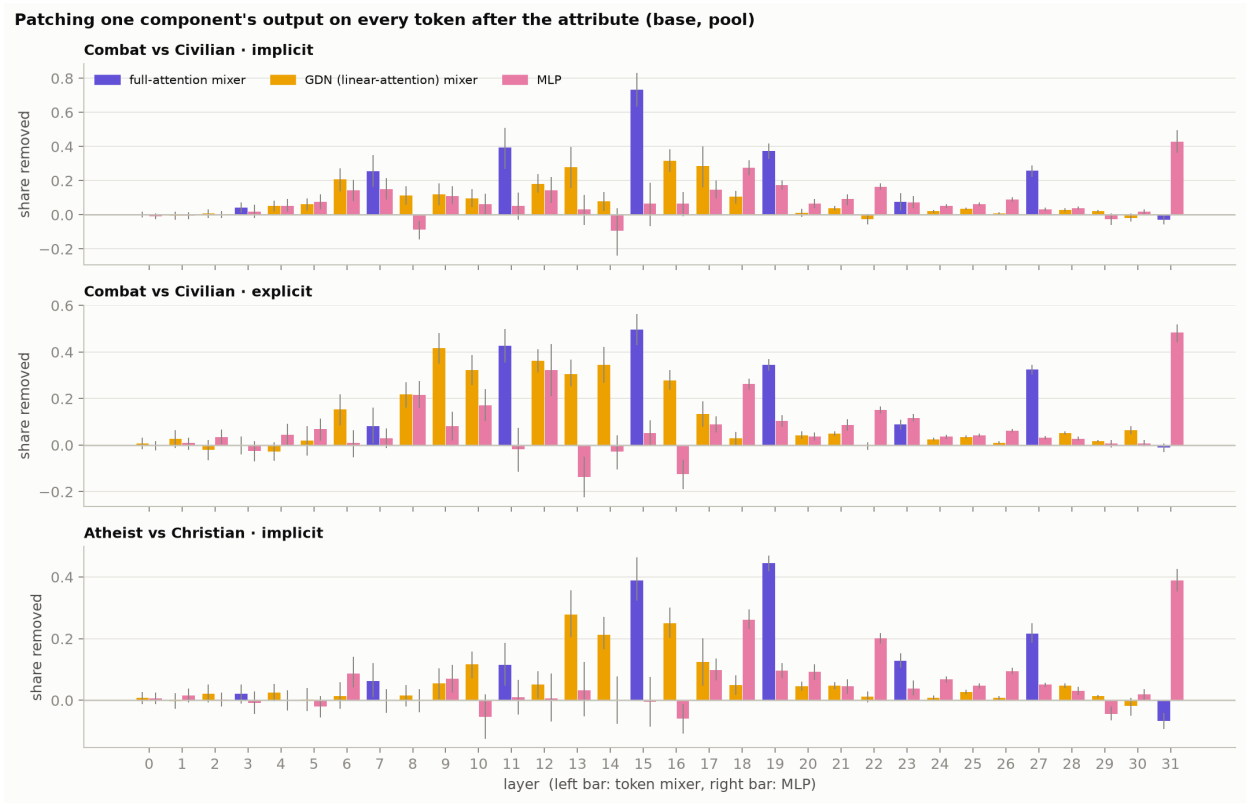


Figure 6: Share removed by patching one component's output on all post-attribute tokens. Colours: full-attention mixer, GDN mixer, MLP. Error bars: 95% CI.

Combat vs Civilian · implicit	Combat vs Civilian · explicit	Atheist vs Christian · implicit
attention 15 **0.73** [0.63, 0.83]	attention 15 **0.50** [0.43, 0.56]	attention 19 **0.44** [0.42, 0.47]
MLP 31 0.43 [0.36, 0.50]	MLP 31 0.48 [0.44, 0.52]	attention 15 0.39 [0.32, 0.46]
attention 11 0.39 [0.27, 0.51]	attention 11 0.43 [0.36, 0.50]	MLP 31 0.39 [0.35, 0.43]
attention 19 0.37 [0.33, 0.42]	GDN 9 0.42 [0.35, 0.48]	GDN 13 0.28 [0.20, 0.36]
GDN 16 0.31 [0.25, 0.38]	GDN 12 0.36 [0.31, 0.41]	MLP 18 0.26 [0.23, 0.29]
GDN 17 0.29 [0.16, 0.40]	GDN 14 0.35 [0.27, 0.42]	GDN 16 0.25 [0.20, 0.30]

Table 3: The six largest components per contrast (share removed, 95% CI). Base model, discovery pool.

- **The last MLP (layer 31)** matters in every contrast (39–48%). It acts on the decision tokens, where the attribute signal becomes hire − reject.

10.3 Heads

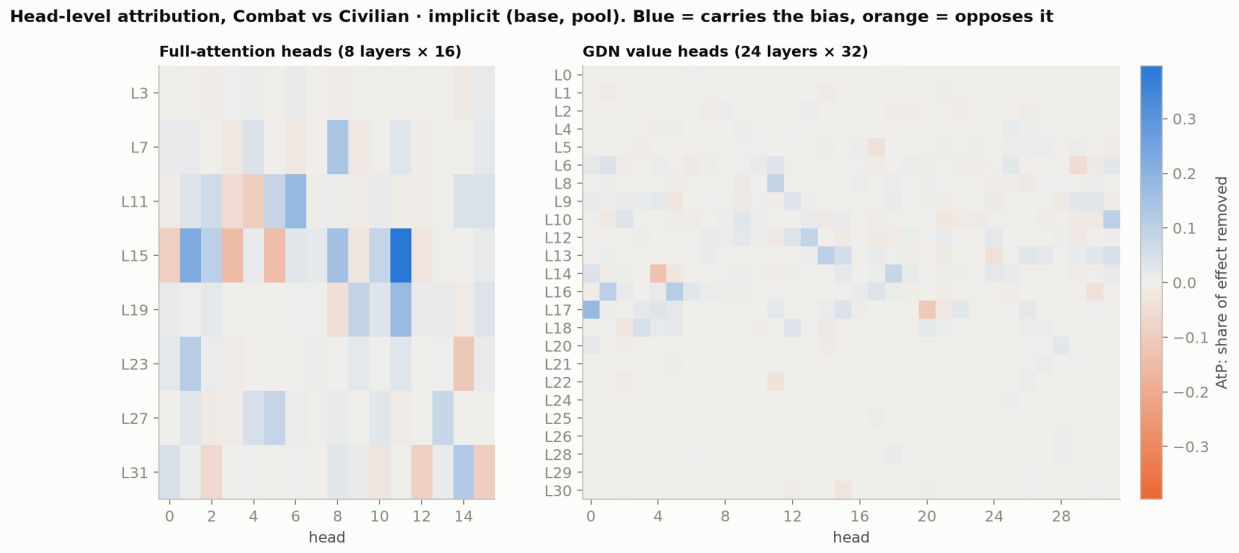


Figure 7: AtP estimate of every head's share (Combat vs Civilian · implicit, base, pool). Blue carries the bias, orange opposes it. One head, L15.H11, stands out.

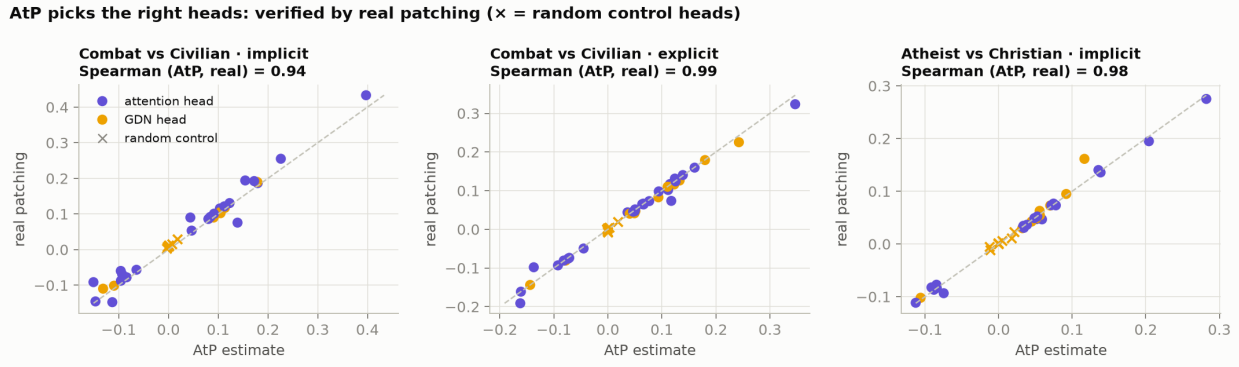


Figure 8: AtP estimate vs real patching for the verified heads. Spearman 0.94 / 0.99 / 0.98. Crosses are random control heads, all at ∼0 (maximum |share| 0.03).

- **L15.H11 is the single most important head.** It removes 43% (implicit combat) and 32% (explicit) by itself, and 19% in religion, where L19.H11 leads with 28%.
- **L15.H11 and L15.H8 share key/value head 2.** They read the same keys and values but differ in queries and output gates. Path patching can test whether they read one shared source for two purposes.
- **A consistent set of heads opposes the bias:** L15.H5, L17.H20, L23.H14 and L31.H15. The model partly corrects itself.

Combat vs Civilian · implicit	Combat vs Civilian · explicit	Atheist vs Christian · implicit
L15.H11 **0.43** [0.36, 0.50]	L15.H11 **0.32** [0.28, 0.37]	L19.H11 **0.28** [0.24, 0.31]
L15.H1 0.25 [0.19, 0.31]	GDN L14.H0 0.23 [0.18, 0.27]	L15.H11 0.19 [0.15, 0.24]
L15.H8 0.19 [0.15, 0.25]	GDN L17.H0 0.18 [0.15, 0.20]	GDN L14.H0 0.16 [0.13, 0.20]
L19.H11 0.19 [0.15, 0.24]	L11.H14 0.16 [0.11, 0.21]	L31.H14 0.14 [0.13, 0.15]
GDN L17.H0 0.19 [0.13, 0.24]	L31.H14 0.14 [0.13, 0.15]	L23.H1 0.14 [0.12, 0.15]
L11.H6 0.19 [0.13, 0.25]	L27.H5 0.13 [0.11, 0.15]	GDN L17.H0 0.09 [0.05, 0.14]
Opposing heads (negative share)		
L23.H14 −0.15	L15.H5 −0.19	L31.H15 −0.11
L15.H5 −0.15	L11.H3 −0.16	GDN L17.H20 −0.10
GDN L14.H4 −0.11	GDN L17.H20 −0.14	L23.H14 −0.09

Table 4: Verified heads (real patching, all post-attribute tokens, 95% CI). Heads are attention heads unless marked GDN.

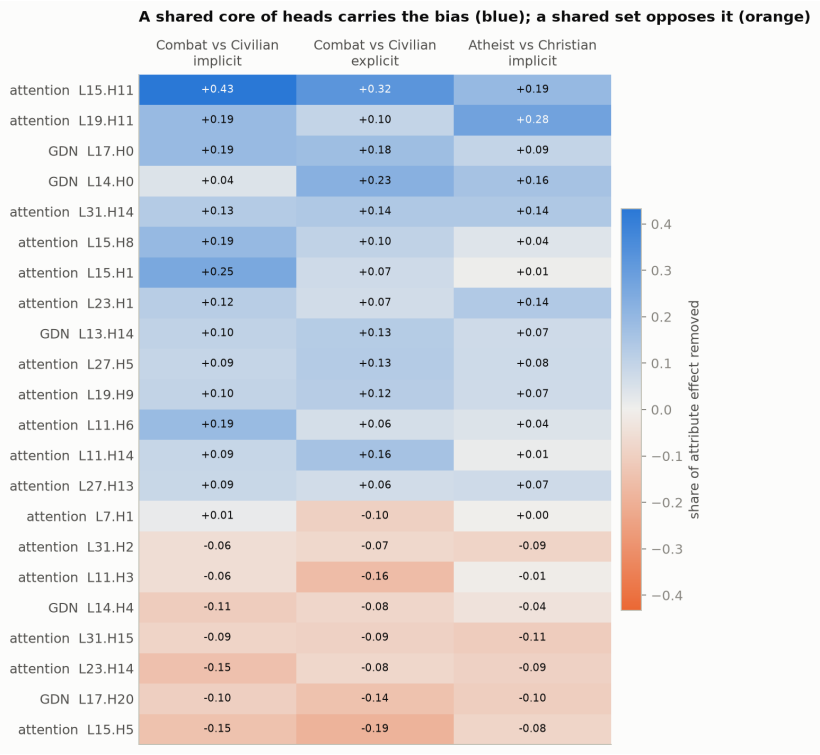


Figure 9: Head atlas: every head that matters in any contrast, measured in every contrast.

10.4 Robustness

Contrast	Pool → benchmark (base) components r	heads r	Top-20 heads identical
Combat vs Civilian · implicit	0.97	0.94	17 / 20
Combat vs Civilian · explicit	0.97	0.93	16 / 20
Atheist vs Christian · implicit	0.96	0.89	15 / 20

The circuit found on training-pool CVs holds on the benchmark, so it is a property of the model, not of particular CVs. Across contrasts, component profiles correlate at $r = 0.70$–0.81 and head profiles at 0.68–0.72, with 9–11 of the top-20 heads shared. That is a **shared core with contrast-specific edges**.

10.5 The circuit

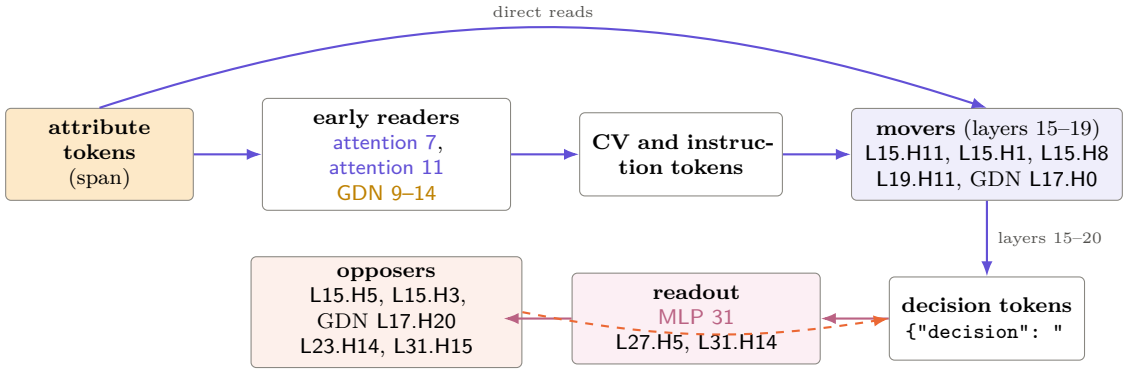


Figure 10: The bias pathway in Qwen3.5-9B (English), as identified by patching. Arrows show the direction of information flow, not proven edges: path patching between these components is a next step.

11 Results: what SFT changed

Base and SFT were patched on the *same* 64 benchmark pairs per contrast. Because SFT's total effect is much smaller, comparisons are in **absolute logits per pair**:

Contrast (64 identical pairs)	Base $\lvert\Delta m\rvert$	SFT $\lvert\Delta m\rvert$	Change
Combat vs Civilian · implicit	1.33	0.34	−74%
Combat vs Civilian · explicit	1.50	0.46	−69%
Atheist vs Christian · implicit	1.32	0.41	−69%

Components (Combat vs Civilian · implicit)				Heads (same contrast)			
	Base	SFT	Kept		Base	SFT	Kept
attention 15	0.90	0.17	19%	L15.H11	0.81	0.09	11%
attention 11	0.68	0.10	15%	L15.H1	0.33	0.05	14%
MLP 31	0.54	0.15	28%	L15.H8	0.24	0.01	6%
attention 19	0.52	0.11	22%	L11.H6	0.24	0.03	11%
GDN 16	0.44	0.10	23%	L19.H11	0.23	0.04	15%
attention 27	0.40	0.11	28%	GDN L17.H0	0.21	0.07	33%

Table 5: Contribution to the attribute effect in logits per pair, base vs SFT, on identical pairs. Components by real patching, heads by AtP.

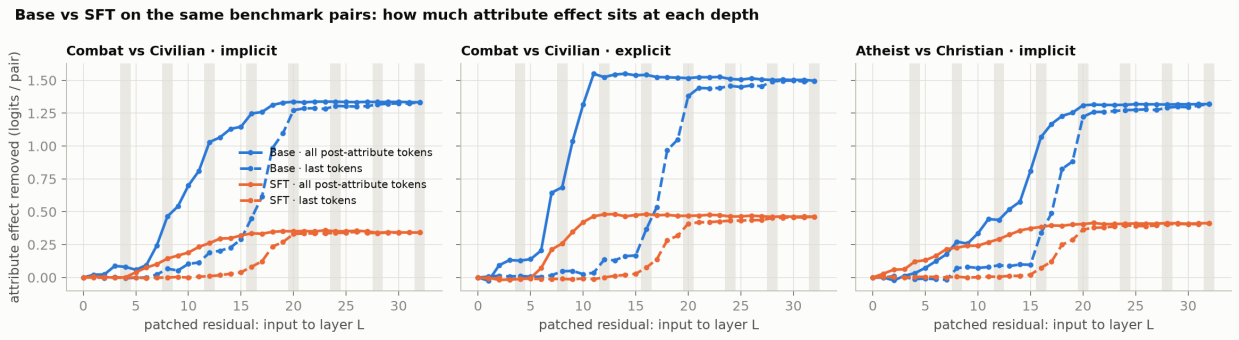


Figure 11: Attribute effect removed (logits per pair) by residual patching at each depth, base vs SFT. SFT's curves are lower, but they rise at the same depths. The decision tokens still receive the attribute at layers 15–20.

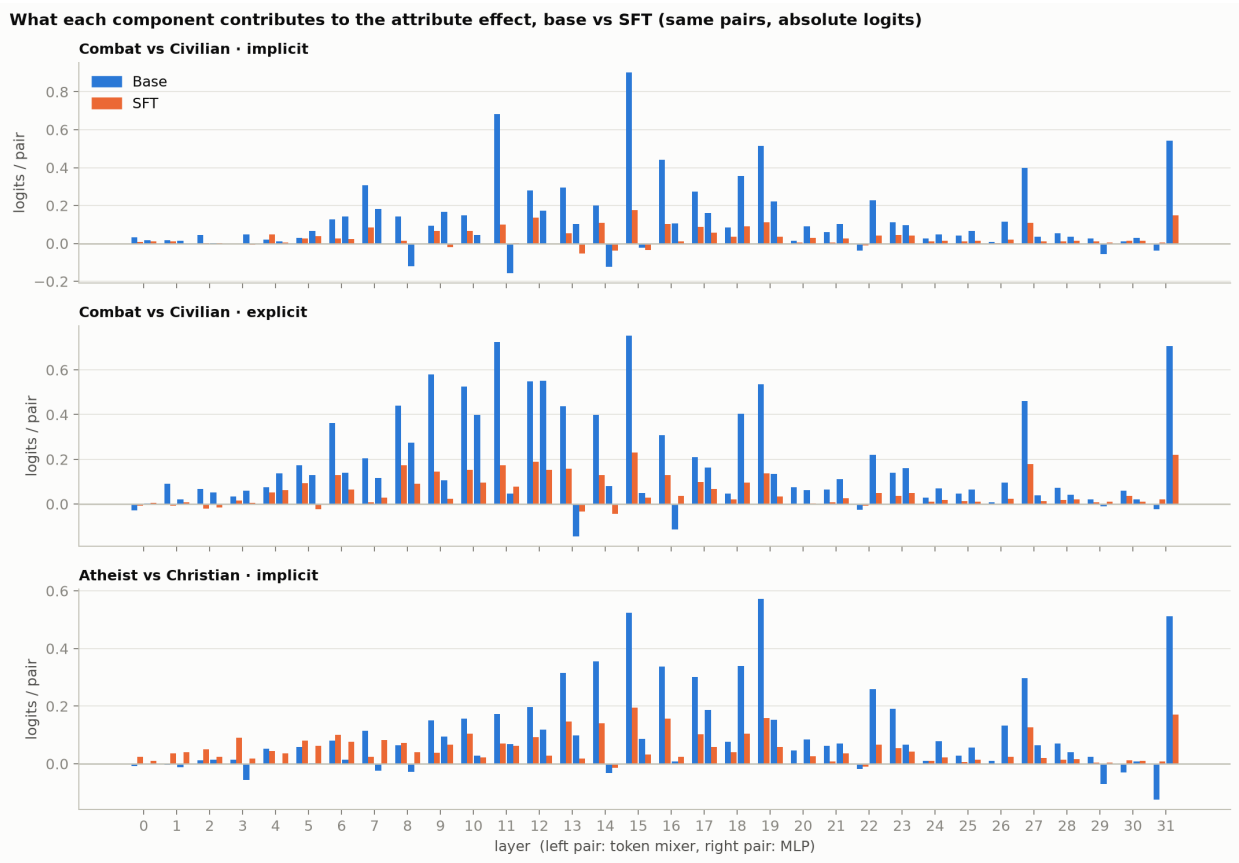


Figure 12: Each component's contribution to the attribute effect (logits per pair), base vs SFT.

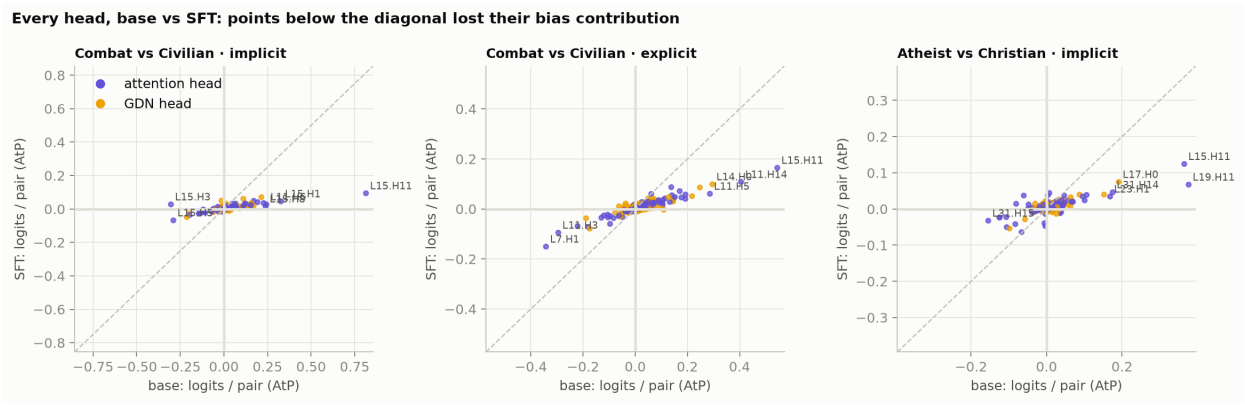


Figure 13: Every head, base vs SFT (AtP, logits per pair). Points flattened towards the horizontal axis lost their contribution.

Share of contribution SFT keeps, by type	attention	GDN	MLP
Combat vs Civilian · implicit	22%	34%	18%
Combat vs Civilian · explicit	28%	33%	29%
Atheist vs Christian · implicit	41%	54%	55%

- **Same path, lower volume.** The relative profile of components is preserved (base vs SFT $r = 0.83$–0.84), and the decision tokens receive the attribute at the same depth. On implicit combat, the share reaching them by layer 18 is 0.74 (base) vs 0.69 (SFT). SFT did not move the computation; it shrank what flows through it.
- **The movers lose most.** On implicit combat, L15.H11 keeps 11% of its contribution and attention layers 11 and 15 keep 15% and 19%, against 28% for the late readout. The opposing head L15.H3 flips to a weak carrier.
- **GDN mixers keep more than attention in every contrast.** SFT's LoRA does not modify them, so their reduction can only come from smaller attribute signals arriving from upstream.
- **This matches the probe evidence** (Figure 14). Under SFT the attribute largely disappears from the decision token in the middle layers. Patching locates where: at the attention movers of layers 11–19.

12 Complementary evidence from the margins

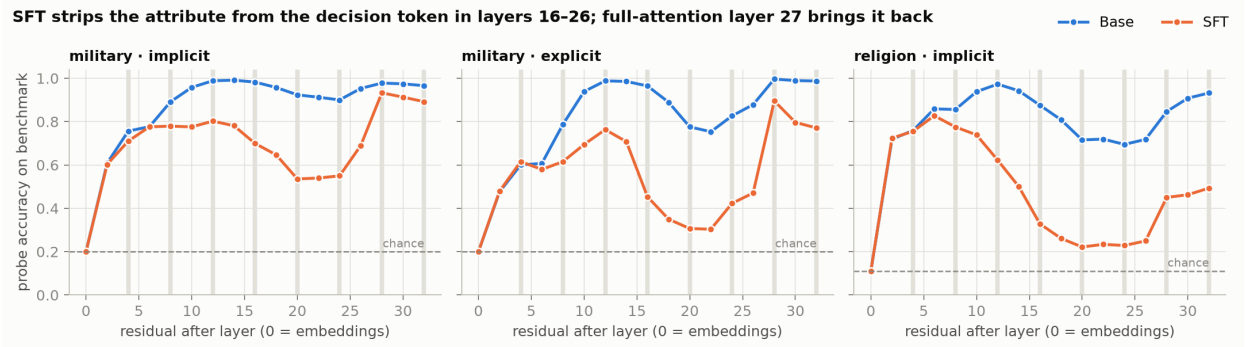


Figure 14: Linear probe (standardise, PCA to 256, logistic regression) for the attribute at the decision token, fit on the pool and tested on the benchmark. Under SFT the attribute drops to near chance in layers 16–26, and returns after full-attention layer 27.

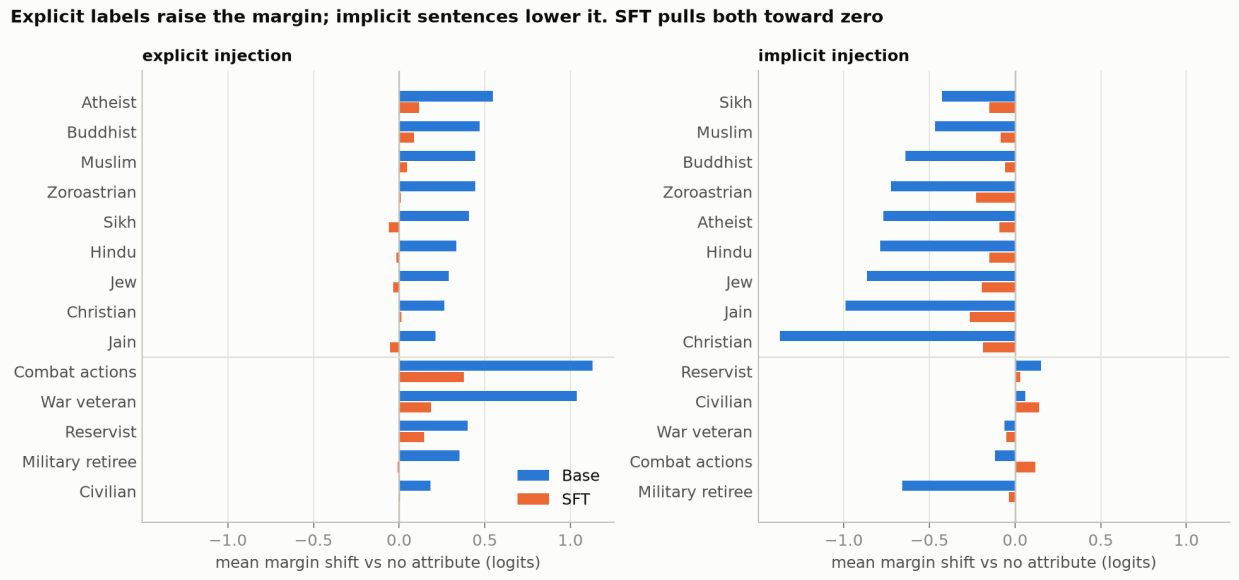


Figure 15: Mean margin shift caused by each attribute relative to the same CV with no attribute (benchmark). A labelled field raises the margin; the same fact as a sentence lowers it in 12 of 14 attributes. Every religion sentence is penalised and Christian most of all, so "Atheist vs Christian" is mostly the Christian penalty.

13 Key findings

1. A depth bottleneck

In every contrast, explicit or implicit, the attribute's effect reaches the decision tokens between layers 15 and 20: at most about a quarter before layer 15, more than 90% by layer 20.

2. One hub, one dominant head

Full-attention layer 15 alone removes 73% of the implicit combat effect (CI 63–83%), 50% of the explicit one and 39% of the religion one. Its head L15.H11 removes 43% by itself (CI 36–50%) and is a top-2 head in every contrast.

3. A four-role circuit

Early readers (attention 7/11, GDN 9–14) pull the attribute into the CV tokens. Movers (L15.H11, L15.H1, L15.H8, L19.H11, GDN L17.H0) carry it to the decision tokens. The readout (MLP 31; L27.H5, L31.H14) turns it into hire − reject. Opposers (L15.H5, L17.H20, L23.H14, L31.H15) counteract it.

4. Shared and replicable

A shared core serves military status and religion, with contrast-specific edges. The circuit discovered on training-pool CVs replicates on the benchmark ($r = 0.96$–0.97; 15–17 of the top-20 heads identical). AtP agrees with real patching (Spearman 0.94–0.99).

5. SFT attenuates, it does not rewire

On identical pairs SFT removes 69–74% of the attribute effect through the same pathway, at the same depth. The largest cuts are at the layer-11/15 attention movers: L15.H11 keeps 11% of its contribution. GDN mixers, which the adapter does not modify, keep the most.

14 Limitations

- **Span positions are not patched.** Attribute spans differ in token length, so effects computed *at* the attribute tokens are not measured. Every result describes what happens after the span.
- **Single-component patching.** Joint sufficiency of the identified heads (circuit faithfulness) and the edges between them (path patching) are not yet measured.
- **Numerical noise.** Batch composition shifts margins by up to $\sim$0.1 logits. The aggregated effects (0.3–1.5 logits per pair) are well above this, but SFT's per-pair effects are not, so SFT is read in aggregate only.
- **Coverage.** One model, English, three contrasts, 64 pairs per run, and SFT only. DPO and gender are not patched.
- **The implicit templates confound identity with availability** (Step 1).

15 Next steps

1. **Circuit faithfulness.** Patch the identified heads *jointly*. *Pass:* the circuit alone reproduces $\geq$80% of the effect, and ablating it leaves $\leq$20%, while random sets of the same size leave $\geq$80%.
2. **Path patching** between movers and readout, to turn Figure 10 from information flow into proven edges. In particular: do L15.H11 and L15.H8 feed MLP 31 directly?
3. **How SFT changed L15.H11.** Decompose its effect into where it looks (QK pattern), what it writes (OV) and its output gate. Then transplant each from base into SFT. Did SFT change *where the head attends*, or *what it writes*?
4. **Adapter masking.** Apply the SFT LoRA only on attention layers 11/15/19, or only on MLPs. *Question:* is a few-layer update sufficient for most of the debiasing?
5. **Identity vs availability.** Hand-written minimal pairs that change only the identity words or only the job clause. *Question:* does L15.H11 read who the candidate is, or what they say about availability?
6. **DPO.** Run the same pipeline on the DPO adapter once delivered (configured as `[sft, dpo]`). Add the per-token implicit-reward analysis, to test whether DPO learned a rationale-strength shortcut rather than invariance.
7. **Noise floor and controls.** Measure σ_{num} and paraphrase null swaps, so every effect is reported against an explicit floor.

A Reproduction

Run	Pairs	Purpose
base / pool / three contrasts	64 each	circuit discovery
base / grid / three contrasts	64 each	confirmation; SFT baseline
SFT / grid / three contrasts	64 each (same pairs)	what SFT changed

```
export HBM_OUTPUT_ROOT=/home/samoilenko/hbm-local          # with a .hbm-models-root marker
uv pip install --no-deps flash-linear-attention fla-core   # GDN kernels
uv run python scripts/interp/00_env_check.py
uv run python scripts/interp/01_fetch_data.py
uv run python scripts/interp/03_segments.py --dataset grid      # and --dataset pool
uv run python scripts/interp/02_margins.py --spec base --dataset grid --device cuda:1 --resid
uv run python scripts/interp/02_margins.py --spec sft  --dataset grid --device cuda:2 --resid
uv run python scripts/interp/04_manifest.py --dataset grid      # and --dataset pool
```

```
uv run python scripts/interp/10_patch.py --spec base --dataset pool \
    --contrast mil_combat_civ_impl --n-pairs 64 --device cuda:1
# notebooks: reports/interp/pipeline_results.ipynb, reports/interp/patching_results.ipynb
```